

it's not inevitable that they must be malicious, they are.

In particular, if anything is designed so that you use a snoop phone to give commands to a device, and the commands pass through the manufacturer's server, that means everything between you and the device is being snooped.

Q. What is the way out of this scheme of things?

A. The freedom-respecting way to design such a product is that your computer should be communicating in some local way and not over the internet. Any device in your house that talks though the internet is a Mal-thing almost certainly, because it enables snooping on you without any special effort. The devices that you accept into your house should not have any way to talk to the internet, but only to your computer. That way, you have total control over what commands you send to those devices.

Any device that has software which can be changed by someone else but the user is already so unjust. It locks you out and turns the device against you. We must fight against this scheme of things where someone else can send commands to that software and you don't know. They're very likely to put in a universal backdoor just so that they can change the software. Why would they respect any of your freedoms? I don't accept such things in my house.

Q. Where do the values diverge between open source and free software?

A. At the outset, I'd like to clarify that free software doesn't mean *muft* software, but *swatantra*. We talk about the essential freedom for all users. The idea of open source was invented in 1998, which is 14-15 years after I started the free software movement. It describes the same practices that were already there in the free software community.

They have the same activities, but different values. With the free software movement, the values are freedom and community. We cooperate so we can all do things and have freedom. Open source doesn't talk about freedom at all.

Q. What does the concept of open source talk about, then?

A. They talk about openness. But openness is narrower and shallower than freedom. Openness just means you can see what the software is doing. Now, when you look at their criteria, it's almost equivalent to the free software criteria. But that's not part of the word 'openness.' They don't make that a matter of principle.

Around the year 2000, they talked about the possibility of making practically better software by allowing everyone to participate in studying it, looking for flaws, fixing them, and so on. They didn't declare a good, convenient but non-free program as an injustice for your freedom's sake. They didn't refuse to use and develop that. They didn't fight it. That's what we did.

We said that if the program's not free, it is an injustice to its user. The users are entitled to have control over the software that does their computing.

Q. Please elaborate on these kinds of licenses.

A. Copyleft is a technique of licensing that I invented because I wanted to make sure that the modified version of my programs will also be free. I use the copyright law as a basis for a license that says: You are given the permission to release and modify the versions of these programs as long as they're under the same license.

There are other free licenses also, that respect the core essential freedoms, but they do not have that requirement. I generally call those lax, permissive, and weak licenses. So, they are not copyleft licenses. But the programs released under them are still free software and are also open

source. But modified versions of them can be non-free.

This is why you need to be very careful when somebody says something is based on free software. It could mean they could have taken a program that is not copyleft-ed and modified, and released it as non-free software.

It could also be possible that they took good GNU plus Linux distributions, some of which are free. Suppose they take one that's free and then add some non-free programs. Now, it's not false to say that it's based on free software. But that doesn't mean it respects your freedom.

Q. How to identify if something is truly free software or not?

A. We have a list of thousands of free programs in the directory at [fsf.org](https://www.fsf.org). And we're always looking for more people to help update the software directory for the highest-possible accuracy and new additions. Because there are still thousands of free programs that are useful but unlisted. Any volunteer can just go to the site and contribute to the directory. We also rate GNU/Linux distributions and other system distributions in the same sense. Some are 100% free, that is, *swatantra* software. You can look at [gnu.org/distros](https://www.gnu.org/distros).

Q. Your journey with FSF had some issues in the recent past. Is there anything that you want to share with your audience?

A. I resigned from the FSF presidency and Board in September 2019. And I rejoined the Board in 2021. And I'm still on the Board, but I'm not the President. The FSF is learning to get along without me as President, which it eventually has to do.

It's well known that people started spreading lots of accusations against me, which were mostly false or based on partial truth. I'm not perfect, but I didn't do anything really horrible. But some people pointed out little things